

rates from countries as diverse as Japan, Germany, Russia and the Czech Republic. They come armed with intricate knowledge of local species and know exactly how and where to find them. Many of them feed a thriving global illegal trade in wildlife, third after narcotics and arms. "The total trade in wildlife products is worth about \$10 billion (approximately Rs 47,000 crore) and if insects make up even a fraction of this, you have a substantial sum," says Tito Joseph of the Wildlife Protection Society of India (WPSI). The hunting grounds are the Himalayan foothills, the Western Ghats and the Eastern Ghats—three regions with the most biodiversity in India.

A single palm-sized specimen of the poisonous Indian tarantula, found only in the Eastern Ghats of Andhra Pradesh, can fetch more than \$1,000 (Rs 47,000) in the international market. Locals say the German 'tourist' was willing to pay upwards of Rs 1 lakh for a still rarer variety of the blue tarantula. A single specimen of the exquisite Kaiser-e-Hind butterfly costs over \$1,500. Other Indian ornamental spiders retail for \$35 and \$150, depend-

SPIDER SPECIALIST

Video grab of the elusive German tourist who has been buying rare and exotic spiders from Visakhapatnam tribals for as little as Rs 100. Species included the blue spider and tarantula spiders which can sell for more than a lakh.



ing on their size. Kucera ran a website coleoptera-kucera.com which offered the arachnids for sale but it was shut down after his arrest.

"I am not coming to India to collect spiders, I merely want to study them," says the tourist, waving a German book on the ornamental spiders of the Eastern Ghats. But the statements of the tribals reveal a different tale. Research has been the common pretext used by most such people including Sveccha, who is associated with the

Academy of Sciences of the Czech Republic, and Kucera. They now have an international lobby of scientists and researchers seeking their release. A furious round of Internet petitions from foreign researchers, sent straight to the Prime Minister's Office, built pressure on the Indian Government urging it to stop "victimising" the duo.

The fact is that the National Biodiversity Act which came into force in 2002 explicitly prevents the collection of flora and fauna from India and



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